

'Bones' of contention

A champion in limbo, a contender in waiting. As calls grow to strip Jon Jones of his UFC title, the heavyweight division stands at a **crossroads.**

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Over 1,80,000 people have signed a petition demanding that the UFC strip reigning heavyweight champion Jon 'Bones' Jones of his title.

For newcomers to MMA, Jones' dominance can be likened to that of Ricky Ponting in cricket — a serial winner. With 13 title defences to his name, the American wrestler is one of the sport's all-time greats.

But growing frustration among fans and analysts has reached a tipping point. The accusation? That Jones is leveraging his superstar status to delay fights.

While most UFC fighters step into the octagon two or three times a

year, Jones has managed that just once in the last 11 years — in 2019, when he defended his belt against Anthony Smith and Thiago Santos. Since moving up to heavyweight from light heavyweight in 2023, he's fought just twice.

His most recent victory came via a third-round knockout of Stipe Miocic — a win that sent Miocic into retirement. However, three of Jones' last five wins have gone to decision, including a controversial split verdict over Santos in 2019.

So what's holding him back?

Age might be one factor — Jones is now 37. The heavyweight division demands an enormous level of endurance, and recovery takes longer. But injuries have played a more immediate role. A torn pectoral tendon forced him out of his 2023 clash with Miocic at UFC 295. That was followed by elbow surgery, delaying his return further.

Then there's the off-cage chaos.

Jones' career has been repeatedly derailed by legal troubles and out-of-competition controversies — DUIs, hit-and-run incidents, domestic violence allegations, and multiple failed drug tests. These missteps have led to suspensions, vacated

titles, and long stretches of inactivity.

What now for Bones?

While the UFC hasn't officially announced his next opponent, the obvious challenger is Tom Aspinall.

Aspinall made an emphatic statement by knocking out Sergei Pavlovich in just over a minute to claim the interim title after Jones pulled out of their scheduled bout. He followed that with another first-round finish, this time against Curtis Blaydes at UFC 304.

Despite his momentum, Aspinall remains stuck with the 'interim' tag — a placeholder while Jones stays inactive.

Aspinall recently claimed he's "moving on" and believes Jones is "retired." But Jones responded with a cryptic message: "A lot of stuff is happening behind the scenes," adding that legal constraints are stopping him from sharing details.

So will Aspinall finally get his shot? Or will the title — and the division — remain in limbo?

Stalled reign: From dominance to doubt — 13 title defences, but no clear next fight. GETTY IMAGES

